



▲ **Lord of the forests**
This 8th-century Slavic brooch shows Veles, the god of magic and music, with a human face and horns. He is thought to be one of the origins of the name of the *volkhvy*, the Slavic pagan priesthood.

There were countless methods of fortune-telling, such as chiromancy (palm-reading), oneiromancy (dream interpretation), and numerology. Astrology, too, flourished. Most astrology was practiced only by the wealthy and educated as it required specialist knowledge and detailed observations of the stars and planets. The popular astrology used by ordinary folk relied on more accessible celestial signs, usually the phases of the moon, to predict the best days to carry out specific activities.

Slavic magic

In the Slavic world, belief in magic was rooted in paganism and persisted well into the late medieval period. Many Slavs resisted Christianization until it was forced upon them by the Northern Crusades (the 12th-century Catholic wars against the people of the Baltic). The Slavs venerated one supreme god, but they believed in an array of lesser deities, too. Their world was also peopled with magical spirits including those of water (such as *mavka* and *rusalka*), forest (*lisovyk* and *leshny*), and field (*polyovyk*). Spirits of the home (*domovyk*) and ancestors were held in particular regard as they were believed to help predict the future and to offer protection.

Slavic witches

Witches, shamans, and wise women played an especially prominent role in Slavic magic, and offered divination, protection against bad spirits, and healing spells. The Slavic priesthood, which admitted both men and women, was called the *volkhvy*, from *volk*, the Ukrainian word for wolf, as well as the name of the Russian god of magic, music, and the watery underworld.

In Russia, *volkhvy* were thought to have descended from wizards and witches who could shape-shift into wolves and bears, while witches of the Balkans, especially Serbia, Macedonia, and Bulgaria, were believed to have dragon ancestors. Descendants of the *volkhvy*, and therefore carriers of witchblood, are rumored to survive in modern-day Ukraine.

The witch also featured in mythical Slavic magic, none more so than the extraordinary figure of Baba Yaga, who was portrayed as a ferocious, wild old woman with terrifying magic powers—sometimes vicious, and sometimes kind. She still appears in many Russian fairy tales, in which she flies around in a mortar, wields a pestle, and lives deep in the forest in a hut usually described as standing on chicken legs—and sometimes she even has chicken legs herself.



► **Good and evil witch**
Rather than riding on a broomstick, Baba Yaga of Russian folklore sits in a mortar and uses the pestle as an oar—here, to chase a girl. Baba Yaga is an ambiguous figure, both fairy godmother and evil witch.